SATURDAY · JULY 4, 2026 · NATIONAL MALL

Washington, DC · July 4th Itinerary

Freedom 250 · Salute to America · Gates 5 PM · Fireworks 10:30 PM

■ SCHEDULE UPDATE — JULY 4, 2026

Due to extreme heat (~107°F), the original plan has changed:

- Gates now open at 5:00 PM (not 1 PM) — do NOT line up before 4:00 PM
- Fireworks at ~10:30 PM (~40 min) — Trump speaks at 9:45 PM
- Military flyovers start 1:15 PM, then every hour until sunset (visible without entering secured perimeter)

■ ACTION REQUIRED — REGISTER FOR TICKETS

Free tickets required · events.freedom250.org · Max 4 per phone number
Verify the confirmation text or your reservation won't lock in.

EVENT AT A GLANCE

■ Date	■ Location	■ Fireworks	■ Gates Open
July 4, 2026	National Mall, DC	~10:30 PM (~40 min)	5:00 PM
■ Cost (Group of 4)	■ Program	🛩■ Flyovers	■ Return
$160–240 (Drive+Metro)	Trump 9:45 PM	1:15 PM, hourly	Free Metro til 2 AM

DETAILED TIMELINE

11:00 AM	Leave Fort Meade — drive to Greenbelt Metro (gates don't open until 5 PM, no need to rush)
11:45 AM	Board Metro Green Line toward L'Enfant Plaza / Smithsonian
12:30 PM	Arrive National Mall. Smithsonian museums open — free, fully air-conditioned
12:30–1:15 PM	Early lunch near the Mall before the flyover crowd builds
1:15 PM	Military flyovers begin — visible from the National Mall area, no security ticket needed
1:15–4:00 PM	Flyovers continue every hour until sunset. Stay cool inside Smithsonian museums between shows
4:00 PM	Begin heading to Freedom 250 security lines — Freedom 250 advises NOT before 4 PM
5:00 PM	Gates open. Pass through security magnetometers (clear bag, ID, no chairs/coolers/aerosols)
5:00–9:30 PM	On the Mall: claim your viewing spot, grab food from vendors, enjoy pre-show atmosphere
9:45 PM	President Trump speaks
10:30 PM	■ FIREWORKS — ~40 minutes · 850,000 shells from 10 launch sites

~11:10 PM	Fireworks end — exit with crowd toward Metro (allow 30–60 min to clear)
11:45 PM–12:30 AM	Free Metro ride back to Greenbelt (Metro runs until 2 AM, free from 5 PM)
12:30–1:30 AM	Drive home from Greenbelt Metro

TRANSPORTATION

■ RECOMMENDED: Drive to Greenbelt Metro · Free Parking · Free Metro after 5 PM
Greenbelt Metro is 20-25 min from Fort Meade. Free parking on July 4. Metro fares are FREE systemwide from 5 PM to 2 AM — covers your entire return trip. Metro runs until 2 AM, which is the only viable way home after 10:30 PM fireworks.

Method	Get There?	Get Home?	Notes
Drive + Metro (Recommended)	■ Yes	■ Yes	Free parking + free Metro after 5 PM. Runs until 2 AM.
MARC Penn Line	■ Yes	■ No	Last train 10:55 PM — fireworks end ~11:10 PM. Need rideshare home ($80–150+).
Amtrak	■ Yes	■ No	Last train ~10:00 PM. Misses fireworks entirely. Need rideshare ($80–150+).
Drive + Park near Mall	■■ Gridlock	■■ Difficult	Street closures Jun 24–Jul 11. Garages jammed for hours after fireworks.

COST ESTIMATES · GROUP OF 4

Expense	Drive + Metro (Recommended)	MARC Plan (in only)	Amtrak Plan (in only)
Parking	$0 (free Metro garage)	Odenton lot — limited	BWI lot (~$9/day)
Transit Fare	$12–24 (free after 5 PM)	$28 round trip for 4	$28–76 round trip for 4
Gas	$5–8 total	$3–5 to station	$5–7 to station
Return Trip	Included (free Metro)	Rideshare $80–150+ (surge)	Rideshare $80–150+ (surge)
Food & Drinks	$120–200 total	$120–200 total	$120–200 total
TOTAL	**$160–240**	**$230–330+**	**$230–350+**

SECURITY & HEAT SAFETY

■ What to Bring

• Government-issued photo ID (required)

• One small CLEAR bag or small clutch per person

• Refillable water bottle (sealed, clear preferred)

• Lotion sunscreen (no spray cans)

• Snacks, cash/card for vendors

■ Prohibited

• Chairs, coolers, glass containers, aerosols

• Spray sunscreen, bug spray, umbrellas

■ Heat Safety (107°F forecast)

• Use Smithsonian museums as your heat refuge (free, AC) from noon until 4 PM

• Bring a refillable water bottle — refill at museum water fountains

• Light, breathable clothing + hat + lotion SPF 50+

• Hydrate consistently — don't wait until you feel thirsty

• Know the signs of heat exhaustion: dizziness, nausea, pale/cool skin

🛩■ Military Flyovers

• Begin 1:15 PM, then every hour until sunset

• Visible from National Mall area — no security ticket needed

USEFUL RESOURCES

Tickets: events.freedom250.org

Metro: wmata.com · free 5 PM–2 AM on July 4

Event: 250.dc.gov

Updated July 4, 2026 · Verify live details at 250.dc.gov, wmata.com, mta.maryland.gov